

P.K.E.

A Ghostbusters-inspired Video Game for the Atari 2600 and 2600+

ATARI® GAME PROGRAM™ INSTRUCTIONS



One-Player
Game

Complete
Gameplay
Instructions

This program, including all original code, design, and documentation, is the work of the author and is protected by copyright law. All rights to the original material are reserved.

This game is an independent, fan-made project and is not affiliated with, endorsed by, or associated with Ghost Corps, Columbia Pictures, or Sony Pictures, the owners of Ghostbusters.

Ghostbusters and all related names, characters, and elements are trademarks and copyrights of their respective owners.

Based on characters created by Dan Aykroyd and Harold Ramis.

This project is created for non-commercial, entertainment purposes only.

Visit Ghostbusters, Virginia at <https://www.ghostbustersva.com> to learn more about the only 501(c)(3) charity recognized by Sony's Ghost Corps in Virginia that gives back to its community through a love of Ghostbusters.

NOTE: Always turn the console POWER switch OFF when inserting or removing an ATARI® Game Program™ cartridge. This will protect the electronic components and prolong the life of your ATARI® Video Computer System™ game.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

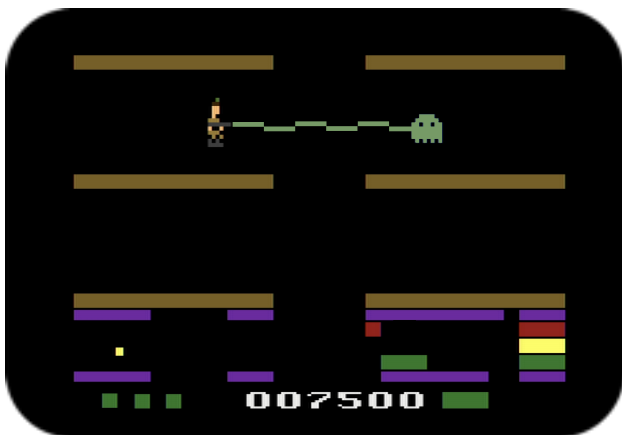
1. INTRODUCTION	2
2. USING THE CONTROLLERS	2
3. CONSOLE CONTROLS	3
4. GAME PLAY	4
5. GHOST BEHAVIOR	6
6. SNACK AND BONUS ITEMS	7
7. SCORING	8
8. HOW TO USE THE P.K.E. METER	8
9. GAME VARIATIONS	11
10. HELPFUL HINTS	12
11. GAME SELECT MATRIX	13

ATARI® GAME PROGRAM™ INSTRUCTIONS

1. INTRODUCTION

"If there's something strange in the neighborhood, who ya gonna call?"

— Ray Parker, Jr.



The neighborhood library has a nasty case of spooks, specters, and ghosts haunting the stacks. It's your job, as head of the city's foremost Professional Paranormal Investigation and Elimination Service, to capture the ghosts without sliming all your uniforms.

2. USING THE CONTROLLERS

"We have the tools! We have the talent!" — Winston Zeddemore



Use the Joystick Controller with this ATARI® Game Program™ cartridge. Be sure the Joystick Controller cable is firmly plugged into the LEFT CONTROLLER jack at the back of your ATARI® Video Computer System™.

ATARI® GAME PROGRAM™ INSTRUCTIONS

Hold the Joystick with the red button to your upper left, toward the television screen.

Move the joystick up, down, left, or right to maneuver the player on the screen. Avoid the ghosts and collect the bonuses. Press the FIRE button to blast your neutrona wand.

3. CONSOLE CONTROLS

“Very simple, really. Loaded trap here. Open. Unlock the system. Insert the trap. Release. Close. Lock the system. Set your entry grid. Neutronize your field. And, when the light is green, the trap is clean.”

— Dr. Ray Stantz

After powering on your ATARI® Video Computer System™, you will see the title card and hear the theme music.

Press FIRE once to skip ahead to the Game Select Screen.



Depress the Game Select switch to choose the game variation. The game variation number is displayed at the bottom of the screen.

Press the FIRE button to begin the selected game.

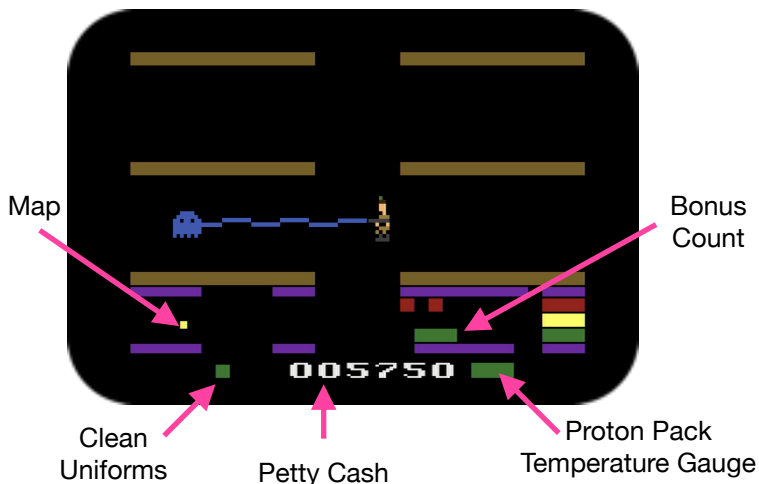
Sixteen game variations are available. Refer to the GAME SELECT MATRIX

4. GAME PLAY

"Why worry? Each of us is wearing an unlicensed nuclear accelerator on his back." — Dr. Peter Venkman

You are searching the library for hauntings. The Easy Layout is the main floor of the library, with everything in neat orderly rows. The Complex Layout takes you to the basement, where things are a bit more maze-like.

If the map is enabled, it appears at the left of the display. The blinking dot indicates position within the library.



On the main floor (EASY LAYOUT), all the bookshelves run east-west with gaps allowing movement in any of the four directions. However, in the basement (COMPLEX LAYOUT), shelves may also run north-south and some paths are blocked.

ATARI® GAME PROGRAM™ INSTRUCTIONS

Below the map is a count of clean uniforms. Contact with a ghost results in it being slimed. When all four are slimed, the game is over.

In the bottom center of the panel is your petty cash balance. When you enter a screen with a ghost, find a position where you can safely fire your wand without making contact with the ghost directly.

The ghost weakens when struck by the neutrona stream. The ghost's color fades to white and then gray. Maintain stream on the ghost until it is weak enough to be trapped, at which point your ghost trap will automatically self-deploy.

Monitor the pack temperature when firing the neutrona wand.

The temperature gauge, an eight-segment bar graph, displays to the right of the petty cash display. Firing the wand causes the pack to heat up due to the generation of proton energy. The pack cools when not being fired.

Green indicates safe operation. Yellow indicates crossing a 50% threshold. Red, and an alarm, indicates the pack has overheated. The neutrona wand is inoperable until the pack completely cools. Overheating the pack results in an expensive repair (see SCORING), but it's better than a meltdown of the fuel cells!

Ghosts become brave when they can tell your pack is disabled.

5. GHOST BEHAVIOR

*"Sir, what you had there was what we refer to as a Focused, Non-Terminal, Repeating Phantasm, or a Class V Full-Roaming Vapor.
A real nasty one, too." — Dr. Ray Stantz*

Five classes of ghost exist. They differ in four characteristics:

- Strength: resistance to the neutrona stream
- Temperament: fear of humans
- Movement: likelihood to change path
- Manifestation: duration of presence

Class	Strength	Temperament	Movement	Manifestation
	I Weak	Timid	Steady	Lingers
	II Resilient	Skittish	Unsettled	Patient
	III Formidable	Wary	Agitated	Restless
	IV Intense	Bold	Chaotic	Transient
	V Relentless	Brazen	Possessed	Fleeting

Just remember, the higher the class, the more of a fight you're in for.

6. SNACK AND BONUS ITEMS

"Well, let's say this Twinkie represents the normal amount of psychokinetic energy in the New York area. Based on this morning's sample, it would be a Twinkie thirty-five feet long, weighing approximately six hundred pounds."

— Dr. Egon Spengler

Seven snack items and one very important book have been placed in the library. Collecting these will earn cash (see SCORING) and upgrades (see HOW TO USE THE P.K.E. Meter).



Pink Donut

Coffee Cup
Yes, Have Some!

ECTO Cooler
Juice Box

Cheez-It crackers



Nestlé Crunch Bar
You've earned it!

Twinkie

Stay-Puft
Marshmallow

Tobin's Spirit
Guide

7. SCORING

“No job is too big, no fee is too big” — Dr. Peter Venkman

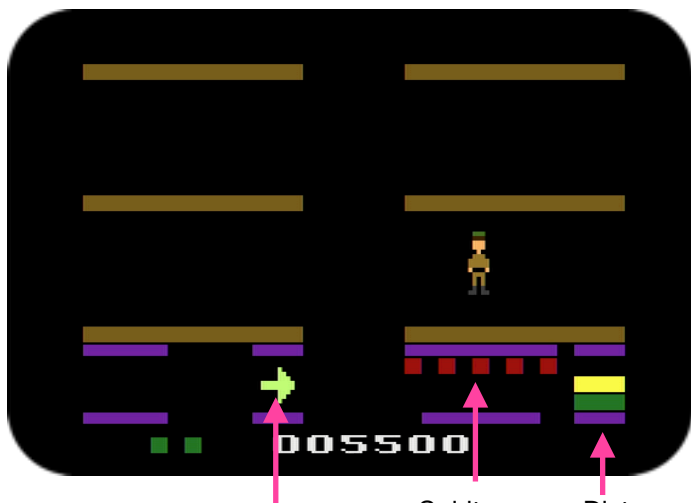
Cash is awarded for capturing ghosts or collecting items.

Ghost Classification	Fee	Item	Bonus
Class I	\$500	Pink Donut	\$250
Class II	\$1,000	Coffee	\$250
Class III	\$1,500	Ecto Cooler	\$250
Class IV	\$2,500	Cheez-Its	\$250
Class V	\$5,000	Crunch Bar	\$500
		Twinkie	\$500
Event	Charge	Stay-Puft Marshmallow	\$500
Proton Pack Overheats	-\$1,000	Tobin's Spirit Guide	\$1,000

8. HOW TO USE THE P.K.E. METER

“Spengler went down there and took some P.K.E. readings. Right off the top of the scale! Buried the needle!” — Dr. Ray Stantz

The Psychokinetic Energy (P.K.E.) Meter is the primary detection and ranging device to locate ghosts, and its readout takes up most of the bottom of the screen.



On the right side of the screen is the distance readout. The meter senses energy being given off by a paranormal entity. As paranormal energy increases, the meter becomes increasingly reactive. Beeps and lights indicate the range.

Once four bonus items have been collected, the P.K.E. meter can also read out the ghost's class. The Spirit Classification display will show one to five lights, representing Class I to Class V. This is only visible when you are within one screen of the ghost.

The P.K.E. meter can also provide the direction to the nearest ghost. This function requires acquiring Tobin's Spirit Guide first.

ATARI® GAME PROGRAM™ INSTRUCTIONS

Feedback	Meaning
	No audio The ghost is three or more screens away
	Slow beep The ghost is two screens away
	Medium beep The ghost is one screen away
	Fast beep The ghost is on the screen.
	Red lights indicate the ghost's class from I - V
	The arrow points in general direction to ghost

9. GAME VARIATIONS

"Human sacrifice, dogs and cats living together... mass hysteria!"

— Dr. Peter Venkman

The difficulty ramps up as you go through the sixteen game variations, based on combinations of these game elements:

Layout: The layout of the library will either be the Easy Layout of the main floor, which allows free motion in any direction, or the more Complex Layout of the basement, with walls separating different sections of the library.

Locator map: Some variations will turn the locator map off, to make it more difficult to determine where in the library you are.

Bonus Item Location: Some variations will place the bonus items in set locations, which makes it easier to find them once you learn where they are. Other variations will randomly distribute them across the library.

P.K.E. Direction Sensor: In some variations, even after locating Tobin's Spirit Guide, you will not receive the ability to find the ghost's direction. That display remains off and you must hunt for the ghosts.

See the GAME SELECT MATRIX for each variation's settings.

10. HELPFUL HINTS

“Okay, important safety tip. Thanks, Egon.” — Dr. Peter Venkman

Ghosts don't hang around. If you exit a screen a ghost is on, it likely won't be there when you come back.

Always have an escape strategy. If the ghost slimes you, you're out, so be ready to run away and bust another day.

Move closer after you stun the ghost. Your stream is more effective at weakening the ghost the closer you are.

Distance is as the ghost flies. The P.K.E. Distance Meter is absolute distance. One screen away *may* be diagonal.

Whoa! Nice shootin', Tex... Reflected energy from hitting a wall will cause your pack to overheat even faster than normal.

Retrace your steps. Bonus items are not all visible from the start, but appear in a sequence. Locate the four basic snacks (donut, coffee, ECTO Cooler, and Cheez-Its) first. This unlocks the second tier of snacks (Crunch Bar, Twinkie, and Stay-Puft Marshmallow). Collect those three, and you'll finally have a chance to read Tobin's Spirit Guide!

Keep Snacking! Finding the Spirit Guide completes your inventory, but your work isn't done! The seven snacks are re-spread through the library! Locating all the snacks on subsequent runs earns you a clean uniform, or if all your uniforms are already clean, you get a **\$7,500** bonus.

II. GAME SELECT MATRIX

Game No.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16
Easy Layout	Blue	Blue	Blue	Blue	Blue	Blue	Blue	Blue								
Complex Layout									Red	Red	Red	Red	Red	Red	Red	Red
Locator Map	Green	Green	Green	Green					Green	Green	Green	Green				
Random Bonus Item Placement			Yellow	Yellow			Yellow	Yellow			Yellow	Yellow			Yellow	Yellow
PKE Direction Arrow*	Purple		Purple		Purple		Purple		Purple		Purple		Purple		Purple	

* After locating Tobin's Spirit Guide

P.K.E.

P.K.€.

A Ghostbusters-inspired Video Game
Designed for the Atari® 2600 Video Computer System™ and the
2600+ Video Computer System™

© 2026 Matthew Younce